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beans) from growers as an experiment because they had zero hope that this would pick up in India. We started with a very small, a two-kilogram roaster at home, began selling online, and in very odd community-driven places because there was no demand. You had to educate the consumer. People who were well travelled were the ones who appreciated quality. They became our first set of consumers.

SZ: When did you realise that this could become a scalable business?

A: After about two years, when we were still a home-run business, we realised this opportunity was big. If not us there would be someone else who would pick up the opportunity, as coffee is one of the most consumed beverages globally. We raised funds, although it was a big task—we were initially unsuccessful in convincing potential investors.

AB: Your first café was at an unusual location. Why Champa Gali in Delhi?

A: At the end of 2015, we raised our first small cheque from the Kirloskar Family Office. We then selected

“Even a small shift in habit represents a massive opportunity. There is enough room for multiple players to grow and for this category to create at least one unicorn”

the oddest possible location to start. Champa Gali used to be a chicken farm. The rent was low, there was no one around, and we could control the environment, and do what we wanted. We built up that location, set up our first live roaster, and started online sales to hotels. That is how our cafe journey started.

SZ: How would you describe that stage of India's coffee culture?

A: If the current decade is called the ‘third wave of coffee’, that was the second wave.

SZ: Where is the growth coming from today?

A: We are focusing on going deeper into a city. Most of